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▶ MAHARASHTRA

THE MAHA KUSHTI ALLIANCE

The stinging legislative council losses in Nagpur and elsewhere renew overt hostilities within the Mahayuti—as Shinde camp calls for his return as CM, BJP says 'the real opposition is within'

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**



IT'S THREE STEPS BACK IN A THREE-LEGGED RACE. Left red-faced in Nagpur and Pune, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) was fated to hear sarcastic demands for the chief minister to be replaced. But there's another bugaboo, as activist Manoj Jarange-Patil claims—backed by purported audio clips—that the ruling Mahayuti tried to bribe him with Rs 500 crore to damage the Opposition before the 2024 assembly poll. Rising above that murk is a third spectre: talk that deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde could join hands with the man he had forsaken: Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray.

It's a time of unprecedented churn in Maharashtra politics. Conspiracists are agog with the Jarange-Patil tapes. The woman speaker: allegedly BJP. The courier? Allegedly, Shinde's son and Lok Sabha MP Shrikant Shinde. The damaged party is unclear. Not so in the legislative council polls. After its commanding victories in a series of local body polls that ran till February, a Mahayuti sweep was expected. In a major embarrassment for the BJP, it lost in two seats. The Nagpur graduates seat has stung badly. Wresting this old fortress from the Congress was a prestige affair for chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, a Nagpur native.

Insiders ascribe his failure to two reasons. Externally, the youth protests. But also strong traces of internal disgruntlement: a section of the Sangh brotherhood stayed away from the campaign; and 4,000-odd BJP votes were invalidated because they curiously contained the same technical error, suggesting design rather than accident. In Pune, too, a personal choice of the Fadnavis camp proved blunderous. Claims by other party probables were overlooked. So was Ajit Pawar's NCP. Their cadre, as well as the Shinde